

BREAK IT UP Police lathi charge at Almaspet Circle, Kadapa, on May 9

report by a civil rights group alleged selective arrests and discriminatory action against Muslims (the police have denied this).

Rayalaseema has seen a series of small flare-ups of late—over Hanuman yatras straying close to mosques, even street cricket mishaps spiralling into violence. The Bharatiya Janata Party, an ally of the ruling Telugu Desam Party (TDP), talks of "Muslim radicalisation", hinting at the presence of the banned Popular Front of India.

A NEW DISQUIET SEEPS IN

Muslims make up about 9 per cent of Andhra's population, but this nearly doubles in Rayalaseema, touching 30 per cent in towns like Kurnool, Kadapa, Nandyala, Hindupuram and Adoni, lending fissile potential to these contests over symbolic space. In Rayachoti, where Muslims objected to the Veerabhadra Swamy idol procession passing through some areas in

Takeaways

- **Kadapa sees clashes over a street crossing's name**
- **In coastal Andhra, Dalit Christians feel the siege**

March 2025, they make up about 50 per cent. Aware of the numbers and of community anxieties, CM Chandrababu Naidu had underplayed his alliance with the BJP in the 2014 and 2024 campaigns in Rayalaseema.

On the coast, the script is different. Here, Hindutva groups are set against Dalit Christians who, they say, claim quota benefits despite converting to Christianity. Akiveedu in West Godavari witnessed clashes on Ram Navami after they moved to garland idols at what they call a dilapidated Ram temple. Local Dalits, who resisted, say the structure was historically a choultry and shrine of village deity Gonthenamma, associated with the Mala community, and call the Rama-Sita idols a later addition. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

BENGAL'

Samik Bhattacharya emerges

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

A CERTAIN DUOPOLY WAS AT THE HEART OF West Bengal's ruling structure before it was abolished by Mamata Banerjee—a model presently being torn apart by a crippling revolt within the ranks. Before her, power was never exercised solely by a chief minister-potentate. Even with Left titans like Jyoti Basu and Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee in Writers' Building, many believed real authority often flowed from Alimuddin Street, where CPI(M) state secretary Anil Biswas wielded immense organisational control. Decades later, Bengal may be seeing the tentative return of that model—in an altered form.

Now, Samik Bhattacharya is no Anil Biswas. The latter was a deadpan, one-man data centre humming in the background, crafting strategy as sharp as his occasional wit. The state chief of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Rajya Sabha MP, by contrast, is more a gregarious user interface: a communicator, a public face, not shy of the dais or of TV.

'THE GOOD COP'

But the way the chips are falling, it seems that as chief minister Suvendu Adhikari reigns from Nabanna as the new regime's sinewy face, Bhattacharya is not subsumed within it. Instead, he buzzes with a certain presence in a parallel sphere. Maybe not quite a fully fledged power centre yet,